complained the protest poem “The Simonie”:

> Once there were merchants who honorably bought and sold,
> And now is that custom abrogated, and has not been observed
> for a long time . . .
> Husbandmen curse and widows weep and cry to God for vengeance,
> very soon,
> For all the problems must be attributed to lords who allow things to
> proceed in this way.[8]

The farmers and peasants of England blamed greedy merchants and corrupt judges for their troubles; the merchants and judges blamed the English barons; and the barons blamed the king.

Edward II had now been king of England for fifteen years. “Ever chicken-hearted and luckless in war,” remarks the *Chronicle of Lanercost*; “quite unlike his father in wisdom and courage,” says Jean Froissart. Edward had lost Scotland; he had presided over the greatest famine in living memory; he had made a fool of himself with Piers Gaveston, and now that Gaveston was dead, he had developed a new favorite.[9]

This was Hugh Despenser the Younger, son of the Earl of Winchester; he was a tall and well-favored man of thirty-six, only two years younger than the king. In 1318, Edward had made Hugh his chamberlain. Afterwards, the royal accounts record a startling amount of money paid out on behalf of Hugh the Younger: supplies bought for his chambers, armor and weapons for himself and his castles, out-and-out grants of money for personal use; new private chambers for Hugh within the royal castle at Winchester. A great new warship built for the king’s fleet was named *La Despenser*. “Confident of the royal favour,” the *Vita Edwardi Secundi* says, “Despenser did everything at his own discretion, snatched at everything, did not bow to the authority of anyone whomsoever.”[10]

Despenser was even more odious to the barons of England than Piers Gaveston had been, but their efforts to convince Edward to permanently banish him were fruitless. Finally, Despenser began to meddle in Edward’s marriage; Jean Froissart writes that he “stirred up such discord between the King and Queen that the King refused either to receive the Queen or to visit her,” and the *Chronicle of Lanercost* suggests that Hugh was actively trying to obtain a divorce between king and queen.[11]

Isabella, eleven years younger than her husband, had already been humiliated by his partiality for Gaveston. Fed up with playing a distant third, she left London and went to Paris, taking refuge with her brother, the newly